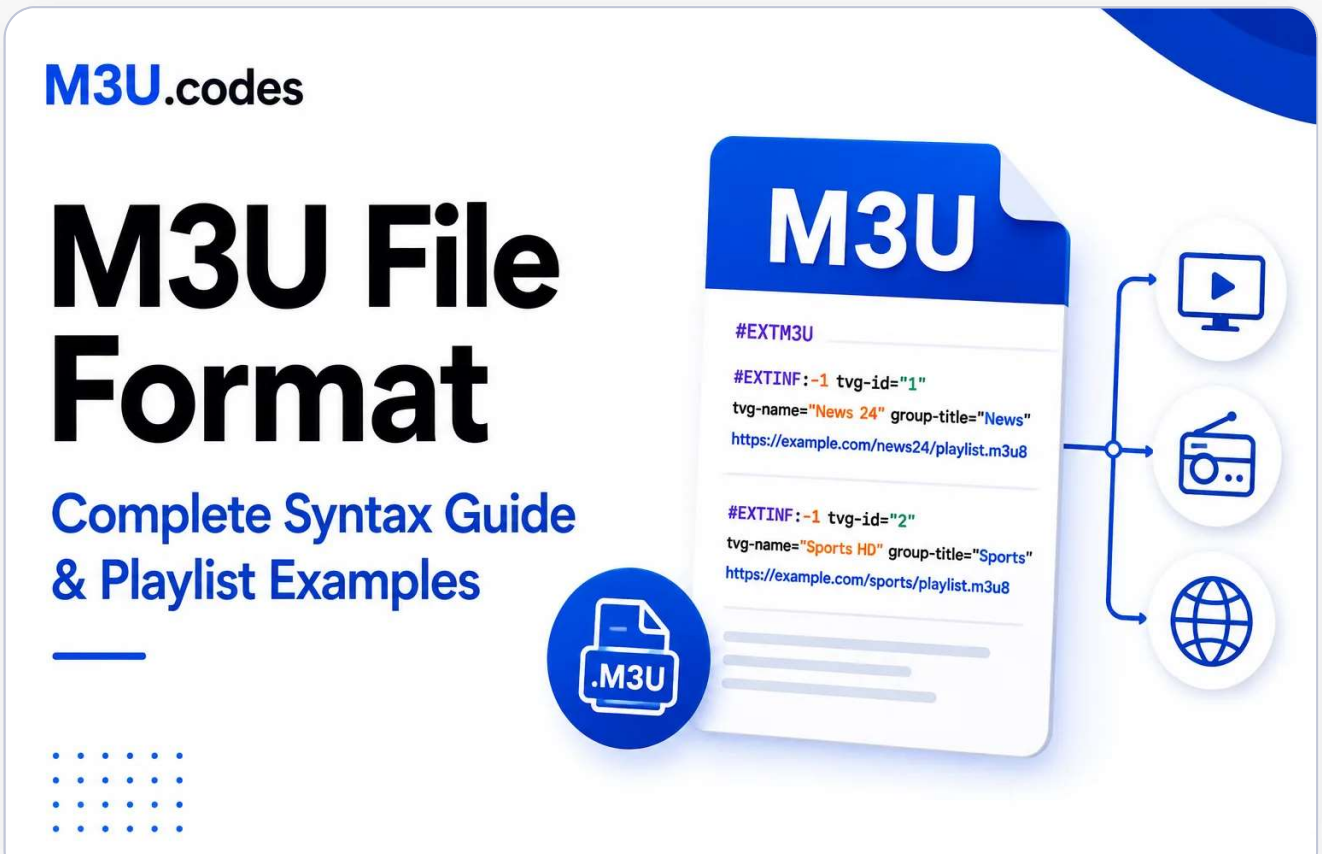
M3U Playlist IPTV

M3U Format: Complete Syntax Guide, Examples & IPTV Attributes

The M3U format is a plain-text playlist standard used by every IPTV player, media app, and streaming device. This complete M3U format reference covers the EXTM3U header, EXTINF tag syntax, tvg-id, tvg-logo, and group-title attributes, file path rules, VLC export, and working copy-paste M3U format examples — everything you need to create, edit, or troubleshoot any M3U playlist.

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M3U Validator

Check any M3U playlist for errors in seconds.

Open Validator

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What Is an M3U File?

An M3U file (short for **MP3 URL** or *Moving Picture Experts Group Audio Layer 3 Uniform Resource Locator*) is a plain-text file that acts as a playlist. It contains no audio or video data itself — it is a list of addresses pointing to media files, either on your local drive or on the internet.

When you open an M3U in a media player, the software reads each address in order, fetches the corresponding file, and plays it. This makes M3U files extremely lightweight — a playlist of 10,000 IPTV channels is typically only a few hundred kilobytes of text.

M3U is supported natively by VLC, Windows Media Player, iTunes, Kodi, virtually every smart TV app, and all major IPTV players. It has become the universal standard for media playlists precisely because the format is simple enough for any text editor to produce.

M3U vs M3U8: Which Should You Use?

The difference is purely about character encoding:

Extension	Encoding	Best for
`.m3u`	System default (varies by OS/locale)	Local files with standard English filenames
`.m3u8`	UTF-8 (explicit)	Internet streaming; filenames with accents, Japanese, Arabic, Cyrillic, etc.

The internal structure is **identical** — both use the same tags and syntax. If in doubt, use `.m3u8` and save with UTF-8 encoding. It will work everywhere a `.m3u` file works, and it will also handle non-Latin characters correctly.

Note: In the context of Apple's HLS streaming protocol, `.m3u8` files have additional HLS-specific tags. See the M3U8 streaming guide for details on that use case. This article focuses on the M3U playlist format for local files and IPTV.

The Anatomy of an M3U Playlist

There are two variants of the format: basic and extended. Almost every real-world use case calls for the extended format.

1. Basic M3U format

The bare minimum — a plain list of file paths or URLs, one per line. No metadata, no track names, no durations.

basic.m3u — Basic M3U — no metadata

```
C:\Music\Rock\song1.mp3
C:\Music\Rock\song2.mp3
C:\Music\Pop\song3.mp3
```

This works, but your player has to open each file to read its title. Large playlists will load slowly, and the display will show raw filenames instead of artist/track names.

2. Extended M3U format

The extended format adds metadata via `#EXT*` tags. It always starts with `#EXTM3U` on the first line, followed by pairs of lines for each entry:

- A `#EXTINF` metadata line (duration + title)
- The file path or URL

extended.m3u — Extended M3U — with EXTINF metadata

```
#EXTM3U

#EXTINF:235,The Beatles - Come Together
C:\Music\TheBeatles\ComeTogether.mp3

#EXTINF:180,Queen - We Will Rock You
C:\Music\Queen\WeWillRockYou.mp3
```

Understanding #EXTINF

Part	Example	Meaning
`#EXTINF:`	`#EXTINF:`	Tag name — required
Duration	`235`	Length in seconds. Use `-1` for live streams or unknown duration.
Comma	`,`	Separator between duration and display title
Title	`The Beatles - Come Together`	Display name shown in the player

The line immediately after `#EXTINF` must be the media path or URL. No blank lines between them.

Absolute vs Relative File Paths

For local file playlists, incorrect paths are the number-one cause of broken playlists. You must understand the two options:

Absolute paths

Point to the exact location on a specific computer.

- Windows example: `C:\Users\John\Music\song.mp3`
- macOS/Linux example: `/home/john/Music/song.mp3`

Pros: The M3U file can be saved anywhere and still find the media.
Cons: If you move the music folder or transfer the playlist to another computer, every path breaks.

Relative paths

Point to the media location *relative to where the M3U file itself is saved*.

- If the M3U and the MP3 are in the same folder: `song.mp3`
- If the MP3 is one folder deeper: `Rock\song.mp3`

Pros: Fully portable — move the entire folder to a USB drive or new PC and it still works.

Cons: Moving the M3U file out of its correct folder breaks the playlist.

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How to Create an M3U Playlist in Notepad

You do not need any special software. Here is the complete process on Windows:

1. **Open Notepad**
   Press `Win + R`, type `notepad`, press Enter. To inspect an existing M3U file, right-click it in File Explorer → *Open With* → *Notepad*.

2. **Add the header**
   Type `#EXTM3U` on the very first line. Press Enter. This line is mandatory — without it, many players treat the file as a basic playlist and ignore all `#EXTINF` metadata.

3. **Add your tracks**
   For each file, add the `#EXTINF` line followed by the path on the next line. Leave a blank line between entries for readability (optional — players ignore blank lines).

4. **Save correctly — this step is critical**
   Go to *File* → *Save As*
   Change *Save as type* to **All Files (*.*)**
   Name the file with a `.m3u` extension, e.g. `MyMix.m3u`
   Set the *Encoding* dropdown to **UTF-8**
   Click Save

   ⚠ If you skip the "All Files" step, Notepad saves it as `MyMix.m3u.txt` — a text file that media players will not recognise.

MyFavoriteMix.m3u — Complete example

```
#EXTM3U

#EXTINF:210,Artist One - Song One
D:\Audio\SongOne.mp3

#EXTINF:195,Artist Two - Song Two
D:\Audio\SongTwo.mp3
```

Already have an M3U file? Validate it first.

The M3U Validator checks for syntax errors, broken paths, missing EXTINF tags, and duplicate entries — before you waste time debugging in VLC.

Validate my M3U

How to Create a Playlist for IPTV Players

IPTV playlists use the same extended M3U format, but the `#EXTINF` line includes additional attributes that IPTV apps use for EPG matching, channel logos, and group organisation.

IPTV #EXTINF attributes

Attribute	Example	Purpose
`tvg-id`	`channel1`	Matches the channel to an EPG source. Must match exactly what your EPG provider uses.
`tvg-name`	`News Network`	Channel name used internally by the IPTV app.
`tvg-logo`	`http://…/logo.png`	URL to the channel logo image. Displayed in the channel list.
`group-title`	`News`	Groups channels into folders/categories in the player UI.

All attributes sit on the same `#EXTINF` line, inside the tag (before the comma). The display name that appears in menus comes after the comma, at the end of the line.

iptv.m3u — IPTV playlist with full attributes

```
#EXTM3U

#EXTINF:-1 tvg-id="channel1" tvg-name="News Network" tvg-logo="http://example.com/logo.png"
http://streaming.server.com:8080/live/username/password/1234.ts

#EXTINF:-1 tvg-id="sports1" tvg-name="Sports HD" tvg-logo="http://example.com/sports.png" g
http://streaming.server.com:8080/live/username/password/5678.ts
```

Editing a large IPTV playlist manually

IPTV providers often supply playlists with thousands of channels from dozens of countries. To trim it down to what you actually watch:

1. Open the file in **Notepad++** (free download — far better than plain Notepad for large files).
2. Use **Find (Ctrl+F)** to search for a `group-title` value you want to remove (e.g. `group-title="Arabic"`).
3. Delete the `#EXTINF` line and the URL line directly below it.
4. Repeat for all channels you want removed.
5. Save with UTF-8 encoding.

Alternatively, the M3U Editor tool lets you do this visually in your browser — no text editing required.

Editing a large IPTV playlist?
The M3U Editor lets you visually remove, reorder, and rename channels in your browser — no text editor needed.

Open M3U Editor

Automated Methods for Generating M3U Files

Manually typing paths for hundreds of MP3 files is not practical. Here are two fast automated methods.

Method 1: VLC Media Player playlist export

1. Open VLC. Press **Ctrl+L** to show the Playlist panel.

Drag your audio or video files into the VLC window.

Drag the entries to arrange playback order.

Go to *Media → Save Playlist to File* (or press **Ctrl+Y**).

In the save dialog, set *Save as type* to **M3U playlist (*.m3u)**.

Click Save.

VLC writes the `#EXTM3U` and `#EXTINF` tags automatically, using the actual file metadata (artist, title, duration) from each track's embedded tags.

Method 2: Windows Command Prompt — one-second folder to playlist

This generates a basic (no metadata) M3U from an entire folder of MP3s instantly.

Command Prompt — Run in the folder containing your MP3s

```
dir /b *.mp3 > playlist.m3u
```

How it works:

`dir` — list directory contents

`/b` — bare format (filenames only, no size or date)

`*.mp3` — filter to MP3 files only. Change to `*.flac` or `*.mp4` as needed.

`> playlist.m3u` — write the output to a new file called `playlist.m3u`

The result is a relative-path playlist — since it only contains filenames, the M3U file works from any location as long as it stays in the same folder as the music files.

To open the Command Prompt in the right folder: in File Explorer, click the address bar, type `cmd`, press Enter. The prompt opens directly in that directory.

Troubleshooting Common M3U Issues

Playlist loads but shows no tracks (red × icons in VLC)

Always a path problem. Open the M3U in Notepad and check:

Does the path match the file's actual location? Navigate there in File Explorer to confirm.

Are there typos? A missing backslash (`\`) or forward slash (`/`) breaks the path.

Did you move the music folder after creating the playlist? Update all paths, or recreate the playlist from the new location.

Is the drive letter correct? External drives change letters when reconnected.

The M3U Validator highlights every broken or malformed path in one scan.

Weird characters in track names (Ã© instead of é)

This is a UTF-8 encoding mismatch. Fix it by re-saving the file:

Open in Notepad.

File → Save As

Set Encoding to **UTF-8**.

If the problem persists, rename the extension from `.m3u` to `.m3u8` — this forces players to read it as UTF-8.

IPTV channels skip or buffer every few seconds

This is almost never a problem with the M3U file itself. Causes:

Server connection limit: Your provider limits simultaneous connections. Use a player that supports reconnection backoff.

VLC loop mode: VLC can loop the stream URL instead of waiting for the next segment. Click the Loop button at the bottom to disable it.

Expired token in the stream URL: Request a fresh M3U from your provider. IPTV stream URLs often embed authentication tokens that expire.

M3U file opens as a text file in the browser or Explorer

The OS is not associating the `.m3u` extension with a media player. Right-click the file → *Open With* → choose VLC (or your preferred player) → tick *Always use this app*.

Best M3U Editor Software

For large playlists, a plain text editor becomes tedious. These tools handle M3U files more efficiently:

M3U.codes Editor (browser, free): Visual channel-by-channel editor. Runs entirely in your browser — no upload. Edit names, logos, groups, and stream URLs. Export when done.

Notepad++ (Windows, free): Text editor with syntax highlighting, Find & Replace with regex, and column selection. Indispensable for bulk-removing groups from large IPTV playlists.

VLC Media Player (all platforms, free): Built-in playlist editor. Best for local file playlists where you want drag-and-drop ordering before exporting.

Mp3tag (Windows/macOS, free): Primarily an audio tag editor, but has excellent M3U export. Lets you clean up embedded metadata first (artist, album, cover art) and then export a correctly formatted extended M3U in one click.

Related guides

What Is M3U? — Complete Beginner's Guide
The history and purpose of the M3U format.

M3U Tags Reference — Every Tag Explained
Every #EXTINF attribute explained.

What Is M3U8? — HLS Streams & Playback Guide
M3U8 in the context of HLS streaming.

IPTV Setup Guide — Set Up IPTV on Any Device
Load your M3U into an IPTV player.

M3U vs M3U8 — Key Differences Explained
When to use each extension.

M3U vs XSPF vs ASX — Playlist Formats Compared
M3U, XSPF and ASX differences explained.

M3U File Examples & Copy-Paste Templates

Copy-paste examples for common use cases.

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